

Smart India Hackathon 2026

Awareness and Orientation for Students and Faculty Mentors

No problem is too big. No idea is too small.

9th

Edition

226

Problem statements

6

Members per team

Dec

Grand Finale 2026

What is the Smart India Hackathon?

Smart India Hackathon (SIH) is a nationwide initiative of the Ministry of Education that gives students a platform to solve real problems faced by ministries, government departments, public sector undertakings, industries and NGOs.

It is not a coding contest. It is a product development competition. Teams are judged on whether they have understood a genuine problem and built something that actually works.

Organised by the Ministry of Education's Innovation Cell (MIC) together with AICTE.

1

Harness student creativity

Channel campus talent toward problems the country is actually trying to solve.

2

Build a problem-solving mindset

Move students from marks and assignments to product thinking.

3

Crowdsource governance solutions

Ministries get workable ideas; citizens get better services.

4

Feed the startup ecosystem

Many SIH prototypes go on to incubation and commercialisation.

SIH 2026 at a glance

21 Aug 2026

Official launch

Launched by the AICTE Chairman; the 9th edition of SIH.

226

Problem statements

First lot released - 172 software and 54 hardware challenges.

30+

Participating organisations

Ministries, departments, PSUs, industries and NGOs.

6

Students per team

Exactly six, with at least one female member - mandatory.

36 hours

Grand Finale sprint

Non-stop build at nodal centres across India, December 2026.

sih.gov.in

Official portal

The single source of truth. All entries route through your SPOC.

Figures as announced at the SIH 2026 launch. Numbers may change as further lots of problem statements are released- always confirm on sih.gov.in.

Why every student should take this seriously

What you gain personally

- A working product on your resume, not a course project
- Mentoring from faculty and industry experts
- Exposure to a real ministry brief with real constraints
- Teamwork, leadership and pitching under pressure

What it opens up

- National recognition and prize money at the Grand Finale
- Internship and placement conversations that start differently
- Startup incubation pathways for promising prototypes
- A network of peers, founders and government stakeholders

What the campus gains

- Visible innovation culture across departments
- Strong evidence for NIRF, NAAC and NBA narratives
- Faculty mentors with live industry-facing problems
- A pipeline of student teams for future national events

Over five million students have competed in earlier editions at 35 or more nodal centres nationwide.

PART TWO

How SIH 2026 actually works

Tracks, themes, team rules, the five stages, and the calendar you must plan against.

Two tracks: Software and Hardware

Software Edition

172 problem statements

Format at the Finale	36 continuous hours of building and iteration
Typical output	Web or mobile application, AI model, dashboard, platform
Judged mainly on	Working demo with live inputs, technical depth, scalability
Suits teams with	Strong full-stack, data or AI skills and fast iteration habits

Hardware Edition

54 problem statements

Format at the Finale	Around five days to fabricate and demonstrate the product
Typical output	Working device, embedded system, robot, drone, instrument
Judged mainly on	Functioning physical prototype, robustness, cost realism
Suits teams with	Electronics, mechanical, embedded and fabrication strengths

A team registers against one problem statement in one track. Pick the track that matches your team's real capability, not the one with fewer competitors.

Theme domains in SIH 2026



Healthcare & MedTech

AI diagnostics, telemedicine, patient systems



Education & Skilling

Personalised learning, assessment, skilling



Clean & Sustainable Tech

Renewables, carbon tracking, waste management



Disaster Management

Early warning, resource allocation, coordination



Heritage & Culture

Digital preservation, virtual tours, language tech



Agriculture & Food

Smart farming, crop monitoring, supply chain



Smart Automation

IoT, robotics, smart cities, industrial control



Water

Quality monitoring, leak detection, distribution



Transport & Logistics

Route optimisation, cold chain, last mile



Emerging Technologies

Blockchain, AR and VR, quantum-inspired methods

Who can participate: team composition rules

1

Exactly 6 students

Not five, not seven. All six from the same institution.

2

At least 1 female member

Mandatory. All-women teams are welcome. This is checked.

3

1 to 2 mentors

Faculty or industry mentors guide the team through the finale.

4

Any discipline

UG, PG and PhD students. Cross-department teams are encouraged.

5

One team leader

Receives portal credentials and owns the submission.

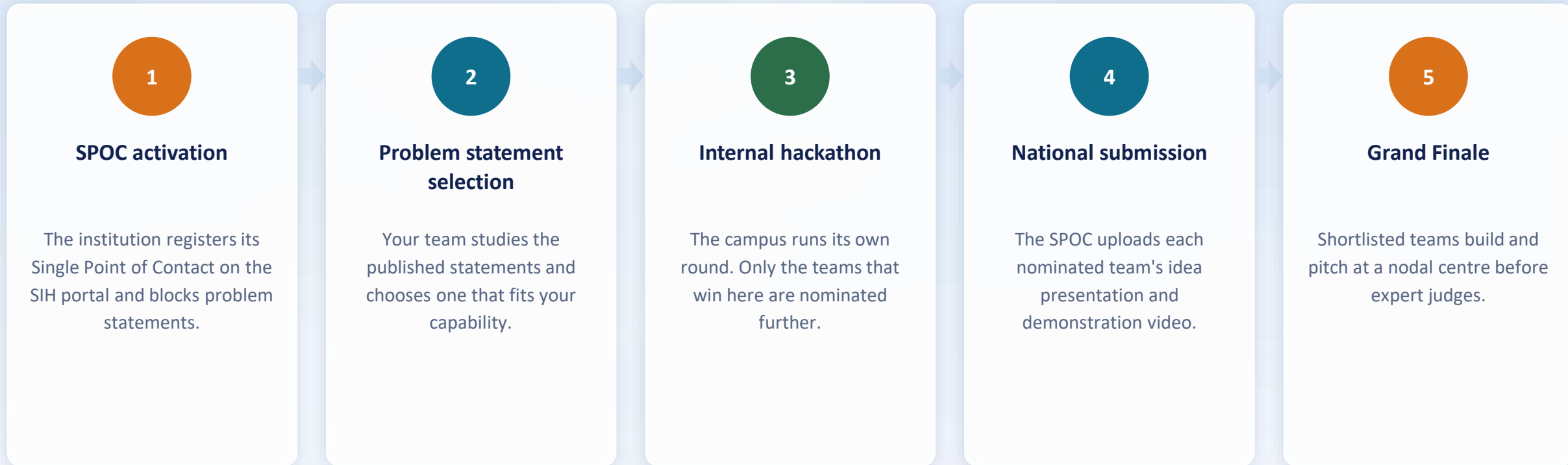
6

Nominated by the SPOC

Only teams cleared through the campus internal hackathon go forward.

Form your six-member team now. Teams that assemble in the last week rarely clear the internal round.

From your classroom to the national stage: five stages



The internal hackathon is the real gate. Treat it with the same seriousness as the national finale.

Indicative timeline: August to December 2026

August 2026

Launch and problem statements

SIH 2026 launched on 21 August. SPOC registration closes and the first lot of 226 problem statements goes live.

September 2026

Internal hackathons

Institutions run campus rounds, shortlist teams and nominate them on the portal against blocked problem statements.

October - November 2026

National evaluation

Idea presentations are pre-screened and evaluated by government and industry experts. Finalists are shortlisted.

December 2026

Grand Finale

Shortlisted teams build for 36 hours (software) or up to five days (hardware) at nodal centres and pitch to judges.

Dates are indicative and are revised by the organisers from time to time. Confirm every deadline with the campus SPOC and onsih.gov.in.

PART THREE

Preparing a submission that survives

Choosing your problem, structuring the idea deck, and the mistakes that end most campaigns.

Choosing the right problem statement

Ask these five questions

- 1 Do we understand what the organisation is really asking for?
- 2 Can our six members build the core of this in 36 hours?
- 3 Do we have, or can we get, the data and the hardware it needs?
- 4 Is there a demonstrable output a judge can see working?
- 5 Does anyone on the team genuinely care about this domain?

Read it ten times

Most eliminated teams solved a problem adjacent to the one that was posted. Open the full description, not the title. List every explicit requirement and every constraint. Then write the problem out in your own words and check it back against the original.

Move early on the portal

Submissions against a single problem statement are capped nationally, and popular statements close early. Shortlist two or three statements you could genuinely execute, rank them, and be ready to move to your second choice without losing days.

Structuring your idea presentation: ten slides

1

Title

Team, problem statement ID and title, institution, members, mentors

2

Problem understanding

The problem in your words, who is affected, gaps in current solutions

3

Proposed solution

One-line description, how it solves the brief, your differentiator

4

Technical architecture

System diagram, tech stack, data flow, APIs and models used

5

Innovation and novelty

What is new, how it differs from what already exists

6

Feasibility and viability

Can it be built in the finale window, resources needed, scalability

7

Impact and benefits

Quantified impact, beneficiaries, SDG alignment where relevant

8

Prototype or demo

Screenshots, wireframes, or a link to a working deployment

9

Build plan

Hour-by-hour plan for the finale with role assignments and milestones

10

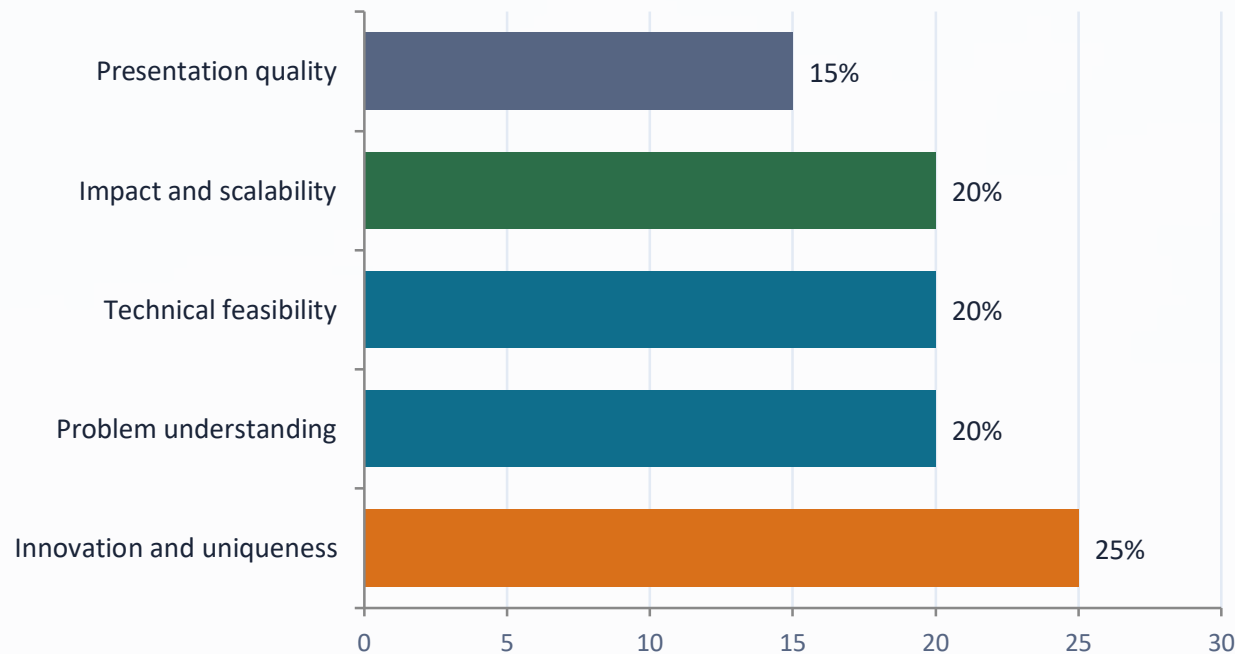
Team and references

Skills of each member, mentor details, citations and sources

Format discipline: keep to the prescribed slide limit, use 14pt or larger body text, favour diagrams over paragraphs, and keep the file small enough to upload cleanly.

What evaluators look for in the idea submission

Indicative weighting of evaluation criteria



Evaluators read fast

Tens of thousands of submissions are screened. Assume two to three minutes on yours. The first two slides decide whether the rest is read.

Depth beats ambition

Saying you will use AI is not technical depth. Naming the model, the data and the failure modes is.

Show something running

Screenshots of a working build outrank the most beautiful mock-up.

Weightings shown are indicative of what evaluators emphasise; the official rubric for the current edition is published on the SIH portal.

Mistakes that eliminate teams every year



Solving the wrong problem

The team read the title, not the full description, and built something the organisation never asked for.



Building ten features, finishing none

One core feature working end to end beats six half-built ones. Judges test what you demonstrate.



No live demonstration

Slides and mock-ups only. Hardcoded demos are spotted immediately when judges change the input.



Breaking a team rule

Wrong team size, or no female member. Administrative, avoidable, and fatal.



Recycling a past winner's solution

Previous submissions are on record and evaluators check. Originality is scored.



Missing the SPOC deadline

Campus cut-offs are earlier than national ones and they are not extended.

Every one of these is avoidable. Read the brief properly, build one thing that works, and respect the deadlines.

What the campus will do, and what you must do

The institution provides

- A registered SPOC who blocks problem statements and nominates teams
- A campus internal hackathon with a faculty and industry jury
- Faculty mentors mapped to teams by domain
- Laboratory, workshop and fabrication access for hardware teams
- Idea deck reviews and mock pitch sessions before national submission

The team must own

- Forming a compliant six-member team and naming a leader
- Reading and shortlisting problem statements independently
- Building a demonstrable prototype, not a set of slides
- Meeting every campus deadline without being chased
- Rehearsing the pitch until it fits the time limit comfortably

Route every query through your department SIH coordinator and the campus SPOC. Do not contact the national organisers directly.

START TODAY

Your action plan for the next two weeks

This week

Form your team

Six members, at least one female member, complementary skills across front-end, back-end, data, hardware and presentation.

This week

Register interest

Submit team details to your department SIH coordinator so the SPOC can plan the internal hackathon.

Week one

Shortlist statements

Read the full descriptions on sih.gov.in. Pick three you can genuinely execute and rank them.

Week two

Approach a mentor

Identify a faculty member working in that domain and get their agreement in writing.

Week two

Draft the idea deck

Build the ten-slide structure with a real architecture diagram and an honest build plan.

Ongoing

Start building

A rough working prototype before the internal round is the single strongest differentiator.

Official portal: sih.gov.in | All nominations route through the campus SPOC

FROM THE PRINCIPAL'S DESK

Bring one real problem to a working solution

Smart India Hackathon rewards students who choose a problem carefully, build something that genuinely works, and explain it clearly. Those are the same habits that make good engineers. Whether or not your team reaches the Grand Finale, the discipline of taking one national problem from a brief to a demonstrable prototype will serve you for the rest of your career. Form your team, choose your problem, and start building.

Explore

sih.gov.in

Register through

Your campus SPOC

Grand Finale

December 2026